the Indian subcontinent, the Gulf, east Africa and southern Europe. But this is something new and unprecedented. The Road is not a revival of some historical role of China as a great trading power. An imagined history is being put forward to seek legitimacy for China's claim to Asian hegemony. What is remarkable is how much of this contrived history is being considered as self-evident in Western and even Indian discourse.

There is little in history to support the proposition that China was indeed the centre of the Asian universe, its economic hub, commanding deference among less civilized states on its periphery. It is on the basis of its economic and military capabilities, its accumulation of knowledge capital, its mastery of science and technology and, above all, its contribution to the global commons that it must claim its rightful place in the emerging world order. Its contemporary rise is indeed remarkable, but history does not give it the centrality it claims.

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